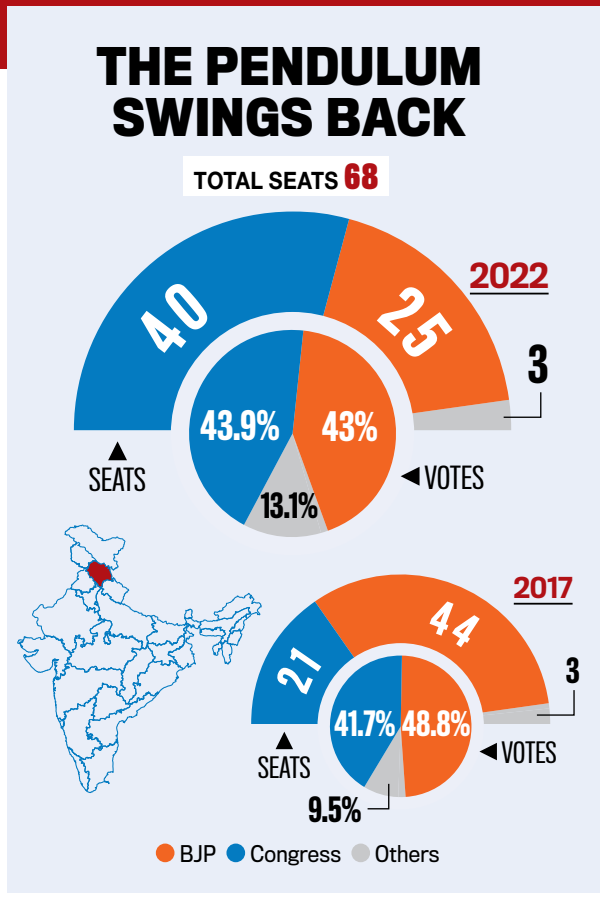


Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

In Himachal at least, the Congress appeared to have learnt from its previous mistakes. New Delhi shed its reluctance to delegate and entrusted the local command with the job. The latter took up local issues, and crafted its own campaign around those. The high command's emissaries only played the role of patrons, keeping the house together. In the end, there were 40 seats in the 68-member House to show for it, leaving only 25 for the BJP and three for Independents.

The next test begins soon: the selection of a chief minister. As of 7 pm, December 8, all new legislators were off to Chandigarh to deliberate on the names. The principal claimants are Pratibha Singh, member of Parliament from Mandi and widow of six-time CM Virbhadra Singh; Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu, MLA and campaign committee chief; and Mukesh Agnihotri, chief of the party's legislative wing in the previous assembly. In April, Pratibha was made state unit chief with a commitment that she would not contest the assembly election. Her son Vikramaditya Singh has retained his Shimla Rural seat and is willing to vacate it for his mother if the party chooses her as CM. However, Sukhvinder—a staunch rival of the Virbhadra camp for over two decades—spies an opportunity too. The high command, rightly wary of the BJP after its experience in Karnataka and Madhya Pradesh, where Congress governments were toppled using dissidents, is keeping a close watch on developments. Former Haryana chief minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda and Chhattisgarh chief minister Bhupesh Baghel are at hand to help steer this passage.

IN HIMACHAL, THE CONGRESS APPEARED TO HAVE LEARNT FROM ITS PREVIOUS MISTAKES; IT TRUSTED THE LOCAL LEADERSHIP

The electoral contest itself was keen to the point that the Congress won only on a hair-trigger margin of 0.9 percentage points in vote share—43.9 per cent against the BJP's 43 per cent. In 10 seats, the victory margin was below 1,500 votes; in five others, leads stretched to a mere 2,000. The Congress ended up on the right side of those because this time it gamed the mess on the other side: factionalism, rebellion and faulty ticket distribution were the BJP's lot. All three victorious Independents—Ashish Sharma (Hamirpur), Hoshyar Singh (Dehra) and K.L. Thakur (Nalagarh)—are BJP rebels. Others—Manohar Lal Dhiman (Indora), Indu Verma (Theog), Tejwant Singh Negi (Kinnaur) and Ram Singh (Kullu)—diverted enough votes to ensure the party candidates lose. Indira Kumari (Chamba) and Kirpal Parmar (Fatehabad) may not have garnered enough votes to claim any credit statistically, but their campaign was damaging enough, creating doubts in the minds of the electorate about the official candidates.

The rebels also put a question mark on the BJP and RSS's leadership capabilities. The BJP had deployed national vice-president Saudan Singh for the past six months in the state. President J.P. Nadda camped for almost a month along with Union minister Anurag Thakur. And a video clip emerged that showed even Prime Minister Narendra Modi speaking to rebel Kirpal Parmar. Nothing worked. The party also wasted the strength of its old guard, not using ex-CMs Prem Kumar Dhumal and Shanta Kumar enough in the campaign. Of the five seats in Hamirpur, Dhumal's home district, it won only Nadaun—and most of the rebels were from his erstwhile camp.

The BJP relied instead on Modi's pro-development, pro-Hindutva credentials, which usually go down well in the state, plus delivery on social sector schemes. In 2019, it had won 69.11 per cent votes and all four Lok Sabha constituencies here. To duck this larger-than-life politics and tap into anti-incumbency against CM Jairam Thakur, the Congress kept its campaign subdued. Rahul Gandhi did not attend a single rally, though his sister and general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra addressed five and new president Mallikarjun Kharge one. The local leaders avoided an attack on Modi, denying the BJP any chance to evoke 'nationalism'. Consequently, the Congress swept Shimla, winning seven of its eight seats, and Kangra (12/15), two districts that house most of the government employees, who bought its promise of returning to the old pension scheme. The angry apple growers of Shimla and the tribal areas in the higher reaches of Kinnaur too leaned towards it. Even so, there are questions and lessons for both the old rivals as they prep for the next battle. Will factionalism end? Can hyper-local work nationally? ■